

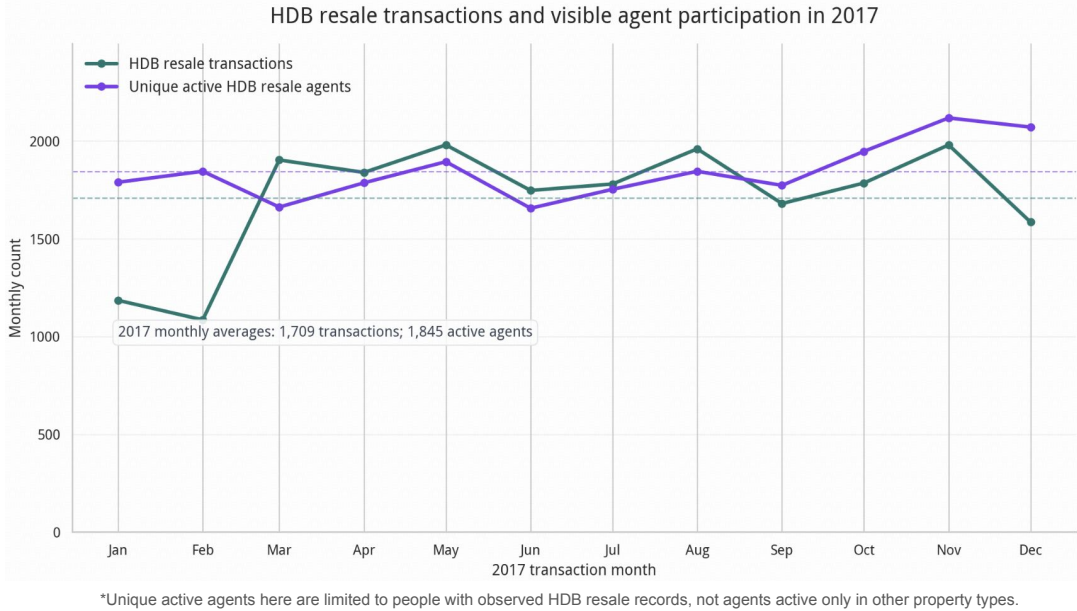
Property Agents Survived the HDB Resale Portal—Here’s Why

A look at the short and long-term impact of the Resale Portal on property agents

When Singapore’s HDB Resale Portal launched in January 2018, it promised a simpler way for buyers and sellers to handle a resale-flat transaction. Buyers and sellers could complete eligibility checks, submit documents and track their applications through one platform. That raised an obvious question: if people could do more themselves, would property agents lose their place in the HDB resale market? The data does show a real short-term dip right after launch. But through the end of 2019, the longer-run pattern looks much less dramatic.

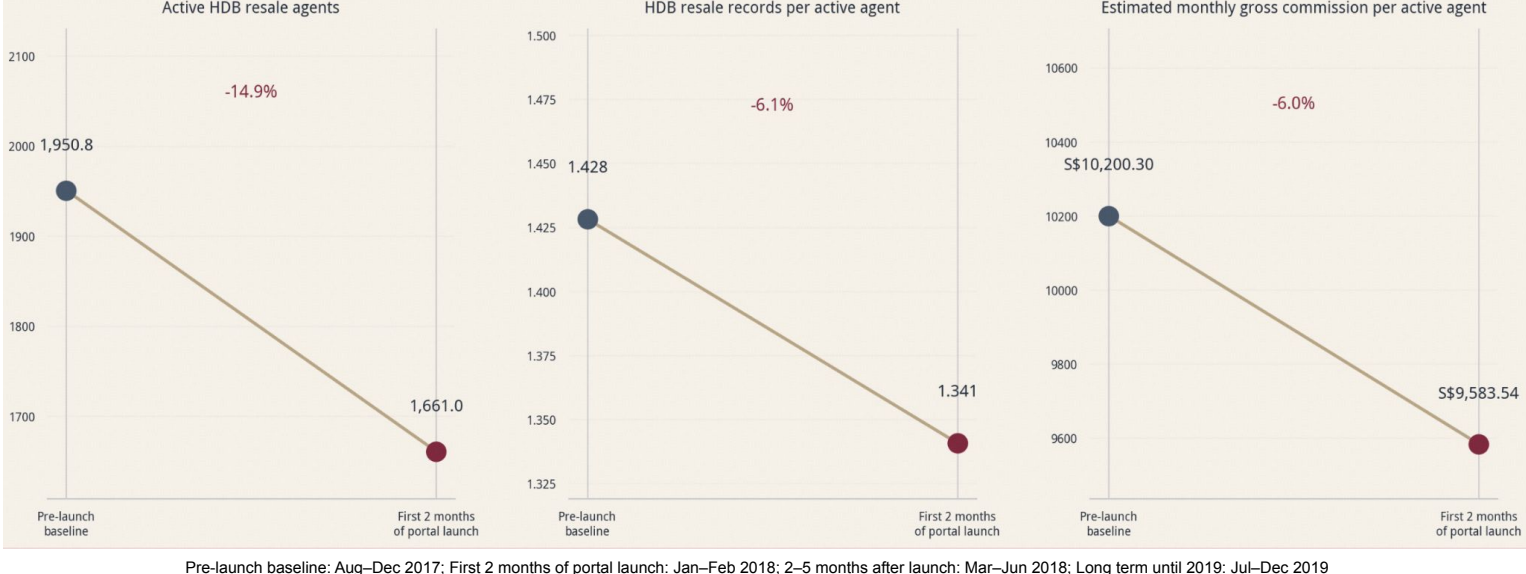
A look at agent numbers

Before the HDB Resale Portal launched, property agents already played a visible role in the resale market. In 2017, CEA recorded an average of **1.52 agent for every HDB resale transaction**, across a market averaging 1,709 resale transactions per month. This does not mean that each sale involved 1.52 unique agents. A single transaction may include both buyer-side and seller-side representation, while the same agent may appear across multiple transactions. Nevertheless, the figure indicates substantial agent involvement before the portal’s introduction.



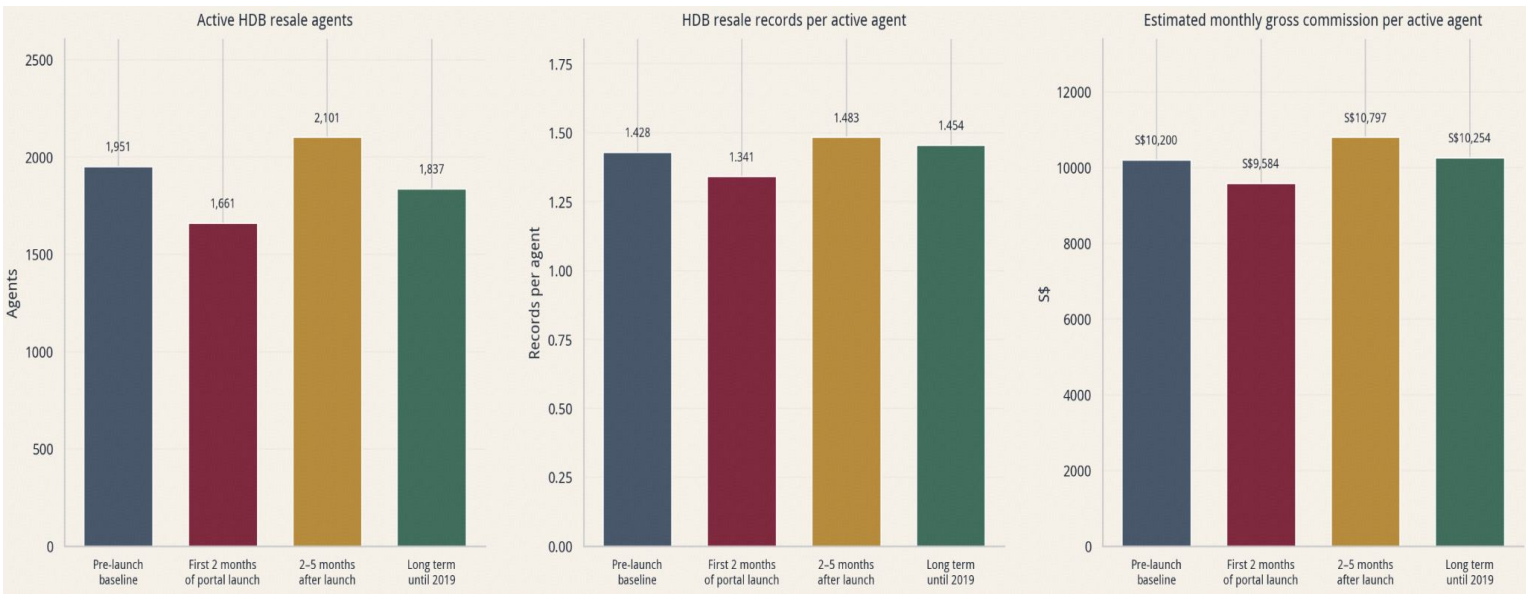
The first shock was real

Immediately after the portal launched, the data show a short-term decline across three measures: the number of active HDB resale agents, HDB resale transactions per active agent, and the estimated monthly gross commission per active agent. This evidence is descriptive rather than causal, but the initial dip is clearly visible.



But the decline did not persist.

About two to five months after the launch—the average number of active agents rebounded to 2,101 per month. Resale records per active agent rose to 1.483, while estimated monthly gross commission per active agent reached \$10,797. All three measures were above their pre-launch baselines.

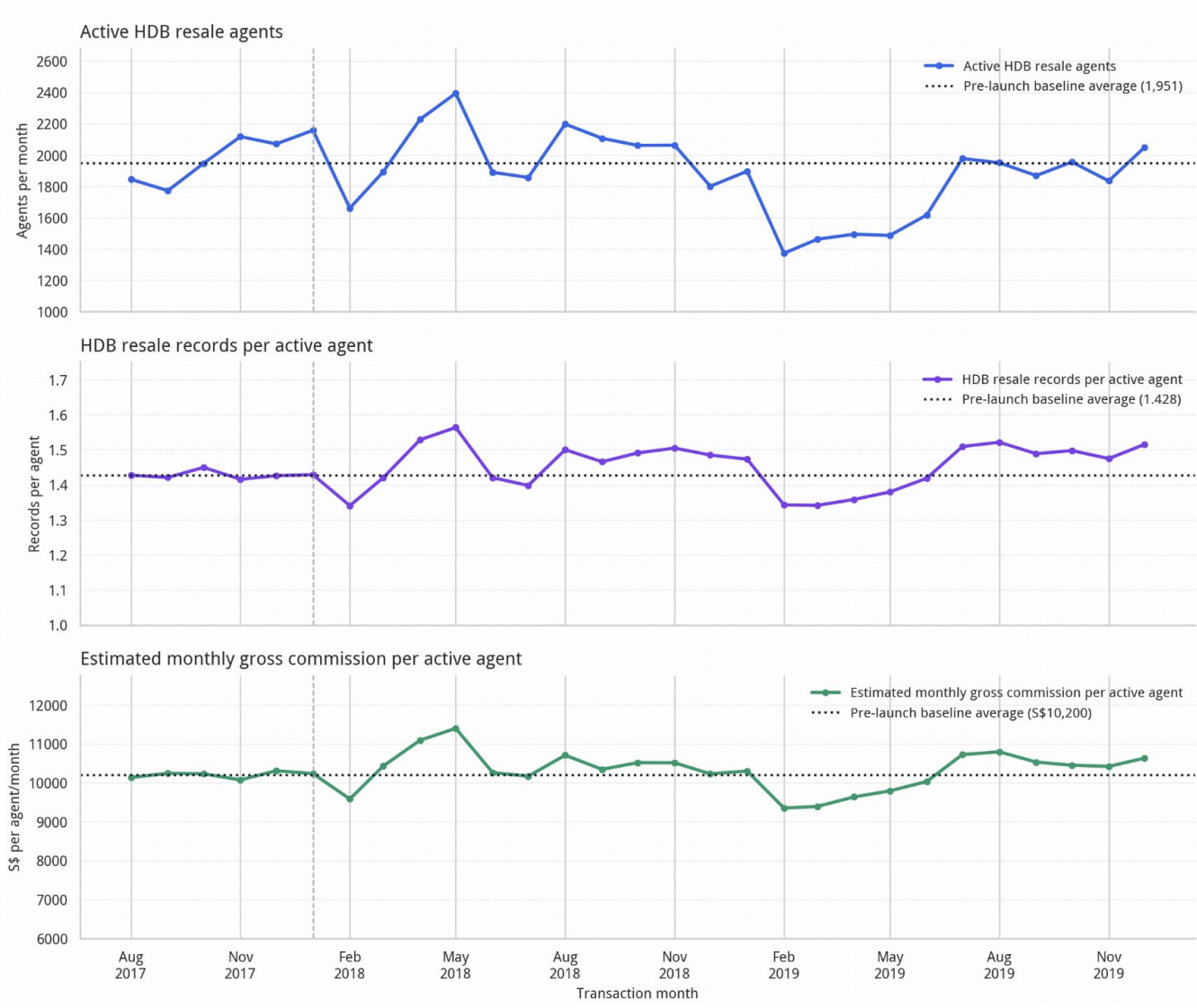


After the early dip, the three tracked measures moved back toward their pre-launch range

Over the longer term, agents’ average business remained broadly stable. Resale records per active agent were 1.80% above the baseline, while estimated monthly gross commission per active agent was 0.53% higher.

The longer-term average number of active agents was lower, at 1,837 per month, compared with the baseline of 1,951. However, the most pronounced decline appeared in February 2019—over a year after the portal’s launch. Its timing makes it difficult to attribute the decline directly to the portal, as seasonal patterns and wider market conditions may also have played a role.

Overall, the HDB Resale Portal appears to have caused some short-term disruption, but the data provide little evidence of a significant or lasting impact on agents’ HDB resale business. The process became more self-service, yet agents continued to maintain a substantial role in the market.



A digital portal changed the workflow, not the need for help

FOR PROPERTY AGENTS

A more digital process can remove some paperwork friction, but it does not automatically remove the need for pricing advice, negotiation, reassurance, and transaction coordination. Through the end of 2019, the descriptive evidence does not show those roles disappearing from HDB resale.

FOR BUYERS AND SELLERS

The portal can still be good news for households. It can make the process more transparent and give people more choice over how much support they want, whether that means doing more themselves or using an agent selectively when they need help.

Sources: Resale Flat Prices and CEA Salespersons’ Property Transaction Records (residential) dataset from data.gov.sg

Estimated gross commission: Monthly mean estimated gross commission per active HDB resale agent. For each agent-month, the method sums town-month imputed HDB value multiplied by a 2% seller-side rate or 1% buyer-side rate, then averages across active HDB resale agents. This is an estimate of gross commission opportunity, not observed income.

Commission-rate reference: [EdgeProp](#)

Limitations and Caveats: Descriptive analysis only; no claim of actual earnings or causal proof. Agent-side participations are not the same as unique persons per sale. The datasets do not provide a shared identifier to directly connect portal usage and agent participation at the transaction level. 2020 is excluded because COVID and source-coverage changes would alter the comparison context.